THE SOUND OF AMELIE

written by

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FADE IN:

INT. GRAND THEATER STAGE - NIGHT

A fourteen-year-old girl, AMELIE, stands in a SPOTLIGHT, hand in hand with the cast of THE SOUND OF MUSIC.

Applause ROARS. It hits her in waves.

Amelie's eyes shimmer with joy.

The cast BOWS. Once. Again.

Amelie lifts her head. She glows under the spotlight.

From behind, we see her silhouette facing a sea of excited faces, hands clapping like a thousand wings.

For an instant, the sound is almost too big, almost sharp.

Then it settles back into warmth.

AMELIE (V.O.) My life began when I was fourteen. It was a miracle.

CUT TO:

INT. TOYS 'R' US (TOY STORE) — SUNDAY AFTERNOON

A doll on the toy shelf: blonde curls, blue eyes, a shimmering silver dress, a fluffy white scarf, and a tiny purse.

AMELIE, wearing heavy glasses and an old, dark red winter school uniform. MOTHER beside her.

Amelie's eyes fix on the doll. She looks up to the shelf labeled "NEW ARRIVALS!" Store noise fades. The doll glows.

AMELIE (TENTATIVE)
Can I...have this?

Mother checks the price tag.

MOTHER ¥699?
(SHARP, AUTOMATIC)
No. That's ridiculous. Put it back.

Amelie's face falls. She clutches the doll to her chest. Her voice cracks.

AMELIE (BEGGING)
But she is so beautiful...!

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (2)

Mother watches, caught between annoyance and a strange tenderness. An idea sparks. A smirk on her face.

Mother crosses her arms over her chest.

MOTHER Alright. How about a deal?

Amelie freezes mid-wail. Hope floods her face fast.

MOTHER (CONT'D) If you make the top ten on your next midterm... I'll buy it.

Mother tries to sound casual, but her eyes flick to the price tag.

MOTHER (V.O.) Top ten. She'll never make top ten.

Amelie stares at the doll. Then at her mother. She swallows hard. Something fierce ignites behind her eyes.

AMELIE (STEADY, DETERMINED)
Deal.

Amelie carefully sets the doll back on the shelf. Her hand lingers on the white scarf.

MATCH CUT TO:

A white towel hanging on the back of a dorm room door, yanked down in one sharp pull.

BEGIN MONTAGE:

* Dorm cleaning day. A cramped room: eight steel bunk beds, girls moving. Rags snapping, desks wiped, blankets pulled tight.

* Dawn. Hundreds of students in identical uniforms surge out of the dorms, arms stacked with thick textbooks.

* Night study with the whole class. Amelie at her desk: geometry, English vocabulary. Her workbook is a map of red X's, circles, and question marks.

* Lights out. Eight girls asleep. Amelie under her blanket, memorizing English vocabulary.

* A midterm ranking sheet goes up. The crowd swallows it. Amelie arrives last, searching for her name but fails.

* In class: the teacher calls on her. Silence. A wrong answer. Laughter—automatic, routine. Amelie is not allowed to sit down.

* Hallway. A shoulder bump that's meant to be nothing. Water splashes to the floor. No apology. No one looks back.

CONTINUED: (3)

* Violin practice: she plays one section wrong several times. Sweat on her face. The teacher’s frown gets more intense.

* Amelie alone at the blackboard, drawing a design. Outside the window, classmates watch, whisper, point, then drift away.

* The chalk drags across the board, a sharp noise—

CUT TO:

Mic feedback screaming in the auditorium.

INT. SCHOOL AUDITORIUM - STAGE WINGS - NIGHT

The auditorium is overwhelmingly noisy. Students pouring in, laughter bouncing off the seats, seats slamming down.

In the dark wings, half-hidden by curtains, AMELIE grips a microphone. In her other hand, there is a crumpled script, torn and rewritten too many times.

A cluster of GIRLS passes close, chatting loudly.

ZOEY (WITH A HINT OF SARCASM)
She's hosting again?

JADE (SWEET, FAKE)
She's just like an angel—

They laugh.

Amelie catches only the word "angel."

Zoey glances toward the wings, sees Amelie standing there. Zoey's smile sharpens.

ZOEY How brilliant you are for calling her that!
(TEASING)
She only gets to stand there because of her mom. Everyone knows.

JADE But CONNECTIONS don't fix everything.

A crueler laugh. They drift toward the seats.

Amelie doesn't move. The words linger. She forces one breath.

An assistant appears, clipboard, headset. A sharp hand signal: Now.

Amelie nods. She takes one more breath, snaps on a bright, professional smile, steps out.

INT. SCHOOL AUDITORIUM - STAGE - CONTINUOUS

CONTINUED: (4)

A small stage. AMELIE stands center stage, alone under a spotlight.

She raises the microphone. A scream of mic feedback slices through the hall.

Laughter ripples. A few sarcastic claps, almost applause.

Front row: PRINCIPALS and TEACHERS frown. One TEACHER stands.

TEACHER QUIET!

The noise dips, not gone. Amelie steadies herself.

AMELIE Good evening, teachers and classmates. Welcome to the 2017 Speech Contest-

The rooms start to get quiet.

AMELIE (CONT'D) -and tonight, I'd like to start with a song.

Students in the audience exchange mean, spiteful glances.

Amelie sings beautifully.

In the audience, faces tilt. Not in awe. In denial. In judgment.

Backstage, at the curtain gap. MOTHER listens. She wears a dark-blue teacher uniform. Her smile is quiet and real.

Amelie finishes. A thin scatter of applause, almost none.

She bows. When she rises, her eyes stay down.

CUT TO:

EXT. SCHOOL CORRIDOR - AFTERNOON

Late sun slants through the corridor window, leaving bright strips and long shadows on the floor.

AMELIE sweeps alone. The broom whispering against the floor.

YUNA comes in a red basketball uniform, juice box in hand. She slows, watching Amelie.

AMELIE (CONT'D) Your game's over?

Yuna nods but doesn't smile. She watches the broom move.

YUNA Can I ask you something?

Amelie keeps sweeping.

AMELIE Mm-hm.

CONTINUED: (5)

Yuna hesitates. The juice box crinkles under her grip.

YUNA Do you know what... 'angelic bitch' means?

Amelie doesn't look up.

AMELIE No. Where did you hear this word?

Yuna inhales. Uncomfortable.

YUNA Right before the game...we were in a circle. Hands in the middle.

QUICK FLASH:

A tight circle of girls in jerseys. Hands stacked. ZOEY leans in with a playful smile.

ZOEY (FLASH) (LOW, SHARP)
Watch out for Amelie. She's an ANGELIC BITCH.

The girls LAUGH. Yuna's face is confused. The team CHANTS.

BACK TO SCENE.

Amelie looks up, surprised. Yuna blinks her eyes. She looks away.

YUNA I don't know what she means. I figure you might know.

Amelie's face doesn't change much. She looks down.

The broom starts moving again, smaller now.

AMELIE (NEAR A WHISPER)
I don't know either.

Yuna stands there, juice box empty. Her mouth opens, then closes.

A long beat of silence. Yuna stays in the strip of sunlight. Amelie sweeps in shadow.

The broom whispers on. Her hand slides up the broom handle, tightens.

MATCH CUT TO:

Amelie's hand on a door handle.

INT. TEACHER’S OFFICE - LATE AFTERNOON

A spacious office broken into cubicles by tall partitions. Only a few lamps are on. The building is quiet after school.

CONTINUED: (6)

AMELIE pushes the door open. Her face holds the tiredness of a whole day.

Two TEACHERS still work at their desks.

AMELIE (CONT'D) (BOW)
Good evening, Teacher Wang. Good evening, Teacher Zhang.

Teacher Wang looks up, gentle.

TEACHER WANG Ah, you're here. Your mother just left.

AMELIE I know. Thank you.

Amelie walks past the cubicles to her mother's desk. The small space is tidy.

On it: a bright red apple. And an open NOTEBOOK: their shared "message book."

Amelie sits in her mother's chair. She wipes the apple carefully with a tissue, like a ritual, then takes a bite.

She reads her mother's neat handwriting.

MOTHER (NOTEBOOK TEXT) Amelie: Eat the apple. Finish the English exercise before you leave.
I also have something to tell you.

Amelie chews. She flips the page.

MOTHER (NOTEBOOK TEXT) (CONT'D) I saw a casting call for the Chinese production of The Sound of Music. They are looking for child actors who can sing and dance. Do you want to try?

Amelie freezes mid-chew. Staring at the word "sing".

A distant sound sneaks in: APPLAUSE. Soft at first.

Amelie's eyes lift, face opens with hope.

The applause sharpens, warps into the cruel clapping from the school auditorium.

A mic feedback scream flickers through her memory.

The overhead light feels suddenly too bright. Too exposing.

Amelie flinches. She tries to pull herself out.

The office returns. Quiet. Paper. Dusty light. Typing sound. Her own breathing.

CONTINUED: (7)

She sets the apple down.

Slowly, she picks up a pen.

She writes beneath her mother's message, careful stroke by stroke, hesitantly.

AMELIE (V.O.) But I can't dance.
(NOTEBOOK TEXT)

CUT TO:

INT. AMELIE'S HOME - DINING ROOM - EVENING

Dinner time. AMELIE stands at the table. MOTHER across the table. FATHER is eating.

AMELIE You know I can't dance!

Confused look. She inhales, jaw tight.

Mother doesn't argue. She watches Amelie. A small smile tugs at her mouth. She keeps it light, almost teasing.

MOTHER But you do know how to sing.

Mother gives her a quick wink. It's an invitation.

Amelie blinks, startled by the confidence in her mother's voice.

MOTHER (CONT'D) Dad can take you to the audition.

Across the table, FATHER looks up from his food.

A beat. Amelie doesn't answer.

She sits back at the table, the sentence echoing in her mind.

CUT TO:

INT. AUDITION ROOM - WAITING AREA - MORNING

AMELIE sits at the sign-up desk. FATHER behind her. A STAFF MEMBER hands her a number tag.

STAFF MEMBER Pin it to your left chest.

Amelie looks up. Her number tag: 319-5

The waiting hall buzzes with children in tutus, curled hair, and exaggerated stage makeup, parents aside.

She rises—among them, she looks like a misplaced adult.

CONTINUED: (8)

She wears her mother's black dress, a top hat, and tall boots. Too sharp. Too tall.

FATHER looks inside his bag. He then hands her a bottle of water.

FATHER Relax! Just have fun.
(THEN, SOFTER)
I'll wait right here.

Amelie takes the water. Forces a weak smile.

She grips the heavy door handle and pulls it open.

INT. AUDITION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

The room is quiet and empty. Three judges sit behind a long table, their faces unreadable in backlight.

A DIRECTOR, middle-aged, heavy framed glasses, clipboard in hand.

DIRECTOR Hi everyone. Today, we'll start with “Do-Re-Mi,” then a song of your choice. Everything will be recorded.
(GESTURES)
Let's start from... far left. You.

A child begins. Then another.

AMELIE waits her turn, standing too straight, water bottle sweating in her hand.

She finally steps forward. Eyes of the other kids on her.

DIRECTOR (CONT’D) Please begin.

Amelie nods. For a blink, the backlit judges look like the front-row teachers at school. She feels dizzy.

But inside her head, a small voice appears: her father's.

FATHER (V.O.) Just have fun.

She inhales. The first note comes out, and suddenly, something in her loosens.

AMELIE (SINGING) Let's start at the very beginning...

Her voice is clear and steady. Sparks in her eyes.

The director flips through resumes. He looks up.

AMELIE (SINGING) (CONT’D) Do a deer, a female deer... Re a drop of golden sun... Mi a name I call myself...

CONTINUED: (9)

CRAYON-WORLD BEGINS:

The lyrics quietly color the air. A small orange deer skims across the floor in light crayon strokes.

A bright yellow SUN floats up near the ceiling, warm and lively.

On the last note, Amelie's name appears in soft pink. It glides forward, settles near the director.

The director's expression changes. He can't take his eyes away.

He glances to the other judges. A flicker of excitement passes between them.

The song ends. Silence hangs. Amelie bows.

DIRECTOR (SATISFYING SMILE)
Thank you, Amelie. Good job.

Amelie steps back, heart pounding.

Later, a STAFF MEMBER steps out with a clipboard in her hand.

STAFF MEMBER The following numbers, please stay: 104-2, 235-7, 319-5...

Amelie freezes. She looks down at her tag, 319-5.

She steps forward with four other kids. They exchange quick, disbelieving smiles.

Amelie's mouth lifts. She rarely smiles.

CUT TO:

EXT. AUDITION ROOM DOOR — MOMENTS LATER

FATHER waits outside. Constant glances at the door.

The door opens. AMELIE appears.

FATHER How was it?

Amelie looks up. Proud, relieved, and almost laughing at herself.

AMELIE They didn't ask me to dance.

She exhales, fingers brushing her number tag.

MATCH CUT TO:

INT. CLASSROOM - MATH CLASS - DAY

CONTINUED: (10)

A big red "72" stamped on AMELIE's math test.

A spring afternoon. Sunlight slants through the windows, catching dust in the air like glitter. Gray, dull room.

She puts the paper half-hidden under the desk, trying to read the mistakes in the dark.

At the front, the MATH TEACHER stands at the podium. Steam rising from his hot tea. He takes a long sip, preparing for his speech.

MATH TEACHER (CLEARS HIS THROAT)
Your midterm exam is next week! As usual, there will be a grade-wide ranking! This isn't just an exam. This is preparation for your high school entrance test! You ALL understand how important this is?

The class answers together in a dull, elongated "YES."

Amelie doesn't participate. Her eyes stay on the red "72."

MATH TEACHER (CONT'D) (LOUDER)
Those of you who STILL can't get past eighty—

He taps the board heavily with chalk, chalk dust falling.

MATH TEACHER (CONT'D)
- I have NOTHING else to say! It's YOUR future, not MINE! Remember. One step behind, and you'll...?

A beat. The entire class responds, machine-like, well trained.

ALL STUDENTS
Always be behind...

MATH TEACHER
Good.
Now. Exam analysis. Take out your last test.

Papers slide. The desk creaks. Students unfolding their exams on tables. Their grades are visible, showing red "90," "85," and "97."

Amelie doesn't move. She keeps her test under the desk. Red circles look like wounds.

The teacher's voice continues, but it fades slightly as Amelie turns her head toward the window.

Outside: early spring. Leaves flickering. A few birds chirping.

For a moment, the room loosens. A sound slips in. The faint echo of a piano. A memory.

AMELIE'S FLASHBACK:

CONTINUED: (11)

DIRECTOR Amelie. Good job.

Amelie's mouth lifts before she can stop it. A secret, tiny smile that she can't resist.

MATH TEACHER (WHIP-CRACK SHARP)
There is NO time for such a SILLY MISTAKE!
Come to my office after class!

Amelie jerks back to the room like she's been caught. Her smile disappears. She lowers her head.

AMELIE (O.S.) Stop thinking about The Sound of Music.
That's over.

She shoves the “72” deeper into the desk drawer.

With the same hand, she yanks out her notebook and begins copying the blackboard. Her shoulders hunch. Her pencil scratches harder.The teacher’s voice turns into rhythm again.

From the corridor window, the whole class bent over their desks, rushing to copy the notes. Sound of pencils scratching paper.

And at the edge, Amelie sits by the window, working hard.

Outside, spring keeps shining. A small group of GIRLS runs to the grass. They laugh, enjoying the sun. Laughter muffles through the pane.

Then distorts into dorm laughter: sharper, messier, closer.

INT. BOARDING SCHOOL DORMITORY - NIGHT (9:15 PM)

A cramped dorm packed with eight girls getting ready for bed. Laughter, whispers, snack wrappers, toothbrushes scraping. Steel bunk beds. Dim overhead light.

Wall phone inside the dorm. AMELIE dials quickly. Clicks.

AMELIE (CONT’D) Hi, Mom.

MOTHER (V.O.) Why so late? I've been waiting for your call.

AMELIE (EXPLAIN)
Our night class ended late...

MOTHER (V.O.) (BRIGHT, CUTTING IN)
I have good news!

Amelie, holding the phone, slips into the hallway, dragging the coiled phone cord with her. She pulls the dorm door shut behind her. Dorm noise dulls.

CONTINUED: (12)

MOTHER (V.O.) (CONT'D) The musical called.
You made it to callbacks.

Amelie freezes, face opens in disbelief. She wraps the phone cord around her hand once, twice.

AMELIE (SMILING, ALMOST A LAUGH)
Really?

MOTHER (V.O.) This Sunday, Dad will take you to the next round. They said you don't need to prepare anything.

The hallway light above Amelie flickers. Smile too big to hide. Behind the dorm door, laughter erupts again. Loud. Close.

She presses the smile down, fingers tightening around the cord.

The cord CREAKS-

MATCH CUT TO:

A piano string twangs as the director tests a note.

INT. ARTS CENTER - CALLBACK ROOM - MORNING

A smaller room. Fewer kids—about ten. Air serious, quiet.

AMELIE sits on a folding chair among other children. Locked shoulders, straight back, stiff posture.

In front of them, the DIRECTOR sits at a grand piano.

Amelie grips her sheet music. Fingers press into knees.

DIRECTOR (CLAPS ONCE, BRISK)
Alright. Sight-singing.

He scans the list.

DIRECTOR (CONT'D) Amelie. Let's start with you.

Amelie's throat tightens. She nods and stands.

She looks down at the page. The NOTES swim. At first it's subtle. Then, the lines slowly blur, the symbols crowd together.

ANXIETY BEGINS:

The page becomes a rough sketch of a cartoon Amelie singing—mouth open, eyes wide—trapped in a looping, rigid rhythm.

Amelie looks down, swallowing. Her eyes zoom closer. The notes on the sheet start to mix together into messy lines.

CONTINUED: (13)

The lines become sketches, showing a short cartoon of her singing. Her voice tight, mechanical, mostly on key but lacking emotion, with an almost imperceptible tremor.

Sketch-style Amelie tries to sing.

AMELIE (SINGING) High on the hill was a lonely goatherd, layee odl... layee odl... layee-oo...

Mostly on pitch, but shaking, weak, airy.

The director stops her with one hand.

DIRECTOR Stop.

ANXIETY ends. Back to reality.

DIRECTOR (CONT'D) You're scared to sing. Your voice is completely different from your first audition. It's too tight.

Amelie's face flushes. She lowers her head. Kids watching.

DIRECTOR (CONT'D) Can you sing the song from the first audition? Just a few lines.

Amelie is STUNNED. She closes her eyes. A breath.

Her father's words return, small and steady.

AMELIE (V.O.) Just have fun.

Her shoulders drop. She looks at the director with trust.

AMELIE (SINGING) Let's start at the very beginning...

The sound changes immediately—brighter, clearer, and with hope.

The director's eyes widen, a smile bursts. He suddenly raises up from the piano. Pointing at Amelie. Eyes filled with excitement.

DIRECTOR STOP there! Yes! That's the voice!

Amelie stops, surprised.

DIRECTOR (CONT'D) Remember that state. Sing like that!

Amelie nods, breath shaking in her chest. Relieved. She shyly sits back down, hiding a smile.

CUT TO:

INT. STREET NOODLE SHOP - NOON

CONTINUED: (14)

A small noodle shop: noisy, crowded, warm. Steam rises in thick clouds from a boiling pot. The chef pours pale broth, drops in noodles, scatters scallions.

FATHER and AMELIE sit by the window. Two bowls land on the table. Steam rises.

Father snaps apart disposable chopsticks, handing one pair to Amelie. Amelie stirs her noodles without eating.

FATHER (CASUAL, CAREFUL)
How'd it go?

Amelie shrugs, eyes down.

AMELIE (HESITANT)
...I don't know if they want me.

Father watches her. He stirs his noodles.

FATHER They don't just want the kids who are perfect.

Amelie looks up.

FATHER (CONT'D) They want the ones who have potential.

A beat.

Amelie looks down again. She takes her first bite.

The steam fogs the window. The world becomes softer, glowing with white.

The white holds, then darkens, slowly.

CUT TO:

INT. DORMITORY - NIGHT (9:40 PM)

Rows of bunk beds in darkness. Eight girls asleep. Soft snoring. Someone's arm wrapped around a stuffed animal.

AMELIE lies awake, eyes open, staring into the dark.

Quiet. Then, very faintly, she hears music. A distant echo of the song "DO-RE-MI."

Amelie doesn't move. She lets herself listen.

A whisper of melody: "Let's start at the very beginning..."

Her focus softens. The darkness blurs. Not a dream.

CUT TO:

CONTINUED: (15)

INT. IMAGINED THEATER - NIGHT

A grand stage. Empty seats. No faces. No judgment. Only one SPOTLIGHT at center stage.

A pair of footsteps approaches, slow and careful.

AMELIE steps into the light.

She wears a navy uniform from The Sound of Music, based on her memory of it from the movie.

From behind, she is small against the vastness.

She looks out at the empty audience, expecting laughter to rise out of it.

Nothing. Only silence.

Amelie's shoulders relax. She inhales. Then, almost too softly to be real:

AMELIE (WHISPERING)
Do...a deer...a female deer...

Her voice echoes back, gently.

Amelie's eyes brighten. A smile tugs at the corners of them, careful and a little shy.

AMELIE (V.O.) What does it feel like... to stand on a stage like this?

The lights dim slightly, as if the theater is breathing along.

Amelie's breathing slows. The stage remains, still quiet, empty, and safe... until it fades with her into sleep.

A distant murmur leaks in. Then another. The murmur grows louder—

CUT TO:

INT. CLASSROOM - AFTERNOON

A cluster of voices. Students packed tight around a ranking sheet taped to the wall. Excited humming. Shoulders touching.

A title, bold at the top:

"PRE-MIDTERM TEST 3 - TOP 10"

Someone points. Exclamation.

STUDENT (O.S.) No way.

CONTINUED: (16)

Amelie pushes forward.

She sees her name on the list: "AMELIE - #10"

Her face doesn't fully move, but something blooms inside her that leaks from her eyes.

CUT TO:

INT. DORMITORY - NIGHT (9:20 PM)

The dorm is loud before bedtime. Girls in pajamas brushing teeth, laughing, phones buzzing.

AMELIE, still in her school uniform, stands at the wall phone, twisting the coiled cord.

MOTHER (V.O.) You finally called.

AMELIE Mom... I have good news.
I made it to the top ten.

A beat.

MOTHER (V.O.) Good.
(PAUSE)
There’s something I need to tell you.

Amelie’s fingers tighten around the receiver. The dorm noise continues, then fades away.

The fluorescent light above her dims. The girls, the beds, and the clutter recede into shadow until Amelie is the only thing left lit.

And in the darkness across from her: Mother, standing there in front of her.

Amelie’s mouth lifts in a faint, nervous smile.

AMELIE (QUIET)
Is it...good or bad?

Mother holds Amelie’s gaze. Her expression remains calm.

MOTHER The Sound of Music called.

A pause. Small, loaded.

MOTHER (CONT’D) You've been cast.

Amelie's eyes widen.

The darkness behind Amelie slowly brightens. It becomes a theater. A warm stage glow rises. A SPOTLIGHT finds her.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (17)

Amelie’s school uniform softens into her imagined navy costume.

Her breath catches. A smile blooms, slow and disbelieving. She looks around the audience with excitement.

But she senses a glimpse of unease in her mother's voice.

MOTHER (CONT’D) (SERIOUS)
Amelie, there's something that we need to talk about, in person.

The spotlight snaps off. The theater collapses back into the dim dorm hallway.

Amelie is herself again: stiff uniform, heavy glasses, phone in hand like a weight. Her smile disappears.

AMELIE (SCARED)
What... what is it?

MOTHER (V.O.) Dad will pick you up after school tomorrow. Pack your luggage tonight.

Amelie's fear rises. She looks down.

AMELIE (PAINFUL, SMALL)
Okay, Mom.

Her hand lowers the receiver onto the hook. CLICK.

Amelie stands still in the dim hallway. Behind her, the dorm noise swells back in: laughter, water running, someone calling out. Life goes on.

Amelie doesn’t move. Then, slowly, she turns toward her bunk, undresses, picks up her toothbrush and cup, and walks to the bathroom.

She opens the tap. Water rushes into the cup, steady, loud.

CUT TO:

INT. HOME - EVENING (6:00 PM)

FATHER washing vegetables under running water at the sink.

In AMELIE's room, she sits at her desk, doing geometry homework. She draws doodles of a navy-uniform character.

A key turns. A click.

MOTHER (O.S.) I’m home!

CONTINUED: (18)

AMELIE covers her homework, steps into the hallway. Father enters with dishes.

FATHER Dinner first.

Steam rises from soup. Warmth. Home. They eat together.

MOTHER (SITTING DOWN)
We're proud of you of getting cast.

FATHER It proves you are a good singer.

Amelie takes a sip of soup. She quietly listens. Her eyes won't settle.

They eat quietly. Father sighs.

FATHER (CONT'D) Well, at first we thought it was just in Shanghai. But turns out the rehearsal is set in Beijing.

MOTHER (SHIFTS, WORRIED)
Your dad is right. After Beijing, it's a yearlong tour, from cities to cities.

Amelie's chopsticks pause. She thinks of Beijing, an unfamiliar city 668 miles away from her home. She looks up.

MOTHER (CONT'D) If you attend... You'd have to leave school.

AMELIE What?

FATHER But your midterm is next week. Your violin certificate is in two weeks. We've prepared for two years.

Silence.

MOTHER There are many things to think about, seriously.

Amelie's spoon slips, clink against the bowl. That clink stretches, deepens...into a GONG.

Amelie compresses her lips.

The dining table blurs at the edges. The warm light fades.

AMELIE'S IMAGINATION — THE GOLDEN PATHS

The dining table dissolves.

A glowing path appears beneath Amelie's feet, warm gold in a dark world. Windows bloom along the road.

CONTINUED: (19)

A window: Amelie at a violin exam, bows steadily, certificate in hand.

A window: a ranking sheet posted on a wall. Amelie ranked #2.

A window: home in Shanghai. Father cooking. Mother reading.

A window: friends walking beside her under spring trees.

The path glows forward into brightness.

BACK TO TABLE.

MOTHER (CONT'D) Let's be an adult about this.

Amelie flinches.

MOTHER (CONT'D) If you go, what will happen?

AMELIE (THINK FOR A LONG TIME)
Just...leaving home...and school.

MOTHER It's not just that. We need to put EVERYTHING on the table.

As Mother speaks—

AMELIE'S IMAGINATION — WINDOW CLOSURE

MOTHER (CONT'D) First, you miss all of your classes; that's 8 classes per day, 40 classes per week, 160 classes per month.

A window shuts.

MOTHER (CONT'D) Then, you miss your exams...now you are lagging way behind!

Another window goes dark.

MOTHER (CONT'D) You will also miss the violin test, and will have to start all over again for two more years.

The violin window flickers, then snaps off.

Amelie's breath shortens. She crouches on the glowing road in her mind, her body small.

MOTHER (CONT'D) Not to mention—you will live in a new city for months—ALONE.

The path narrows.

CONTINUED: (20)

MOTHER (CONT'D) How do you even deal with rumors at school?

Classmates' screaming laughs burst out and echo behind.

CLASSMATE A She dropped out of school!

CLASSMATE B (TOO EXCITED)
I bet she never comes back!

CLASSMATE C (TEASING, SHARP)
I heard she'll get too FAMOUS to be with us.

MOTHER And... we don't know the company at all. What if they TORTURE you on the tour?

The remaining windows blink, then shutter fast, one by one.

The golden road now leads to nowhere.

BACK TO TABLE.

Amelie sits very still. Eyes wide. Stunned.

MOTHER (CONT'D) No one allows me to let you go. Your aunt, your uncle, your grandma... They even blamed me for letting you audition.

FATHER (FINALLY SPEAKS)
Your mother is right. There are too many uncertainties ahead.

Mother exhales.

MOTHER But...I'm not saying no.

Amelie suspicious. She stares at the soup.

MOTHER (CONT'D) (SIGHS)
I'm saying... if you really want to go, at least we need to know how.

She leans forward, determined.

MOTHER (CONT'D) There's a solution to every problem.

AMELIE Like what?

MOTHER You tell me.

Amelie searches her mind but only finds locked windows.

AMELIE I can't think of any...

CONTINUED: (21)

MOTHER (ADVISING)
For example. Can you ask a teacher to email class notes daily?

AMELIE No one does that.

MOTHER Friends?

AMELIE No smartphones allowed.

Mother swallows. Tries not to show frustration.

MOTHER Alright. Violin test? Any solution?

Amelie stares into her bowl. Steam rises, fogging her vision.

AMELIE Maybe...I practice in Beijing...and fly back for the test.

Mother almost smiles, relieved.

MOTHER Okay. Can you fly back alone?

Amelie freezes.

Airport. Taxi. A city that swallows people whole. Adults passing too fast. No one to ask for help.

Her breath catches. She shakes her head.

AMELIE ...I really don't know.

Mother looks to Father. Father's face is unreadable, but his silence says, "Let's end here."

Amelie panics.

A while of silence. Mother and Father watches.

MOTHER Then tell me what you think could work.

Amelie's voice comes out sharp, but uncertain.

AMELIE (STUTTERING)
I think I can't do it.

Father exhales with visible relief.

FATHER It's alright. At least your grades are going up.

Mother's face tightens. She recognizes surrender.

MOTHER Are you sure?

CONTINUED: (22)

Amelie sighs. Eyes down.

AMELIE There is no way I can do it.

She leaves the table. Mother and Father sit at the table.

Mother takes a shaky breath and gazes blankly at her bowl.

FATHER (QUIET)
I think it's best for her. Education matters.

Mother doesn't respond. She stands up and leaves the table.

CUT TO:

INT. AMELIE'S BEDROOM - NIGHT (9:45 PM)

AMELIE lies on her bed with a book open, eyes scanning without reading.

Knocks on the door. No response. MOTHER peeks her head in.

MOTHER Can I come in?

Door opens. Mother walks in. Large box in her hand—the beautiful doll from Toys R' Us.

Amelie looks up. Face surprised and perplexed.

AMELIE Wait...You bought me that doll?!

MOTHER (SMILE)
Dad and I want to let you know how hard you've been working.
(SIT ON BED)
And...you've passed the bet. We are so proud.

Amelie puts the book aside, unwraps the box carefully. The doll appears, perfect and unreal.

MOTHER (CONT'D) I know...You've made a very hard choice. I hope it's the one that's right for you.

Amelie's fingers gently trace the eyelashes, the tiny lips, the cherry cheek, bright, white scarf around the dress.

AMELIE ...I hope so.

Mother pats Amelie on her head. She stands up, walks to the door.

Just before leaving, she stops, turns around.

MOTHER I just want to confirm one last thing.
(PAUSE)
(MORE)

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (23)

MOTHER (CONT'D)
Did you make this decision for Mom and Dad? ... Or for yourself?

Something inside Amelie's eyes widens.

MOTHER (CONT'D) I hope you're making this decision for yourself. Good night.

Door closes. Amelie left alone with the doll.

She looks at the doll on her lap. Her vision blurs.

AMELIE'S IMAGINATION — THE CROSSROADS

The bedroom falls away, leaving AMELIE and the doll in darkness.

Behind the doll. Amelie's navy-uniformed self appears. Far.

That alternate Amelie turns. Looks back.

Real Amelie tries to lean around the doll, but fails.

The doll's glass eyes, without a blink, catch the light.

MATCH CUT TO:

* DOLL'S EYES

* AMELIE'S EYES, widening.

* DOLL'S TINY NOSE.

* AMELIE'S LONG NOSE.

* DOLL'S CHERRY LIPS.

* AMELIE'S PALE LIPS

Amelie realizes something. Her mouth opens.

She stares at the doll. The doll distorts.

A faint plastic sheen creeps over Amelie's fingers and face. Her smile twitches into a polite one. Fixed.

Behind the doll, the navy-uniformed Amelie begins to fade. Her outline softens. Her smile slips away.

Present Amelie panics.

The plastic sheen has crawled up her forearms, smooth and glossy. She digs her nails into it.

Crack. The sheen fractures like thin ice.

CONTINUED: (24)

Amelie rips harder, breath stuttering, tearing away every peel desperately.

The doll doesn't move. Still smiling. Simply watching.

Amelie rips the last piece of sheen. She steps back, then lunges forward with both arms out, bracing to shove the doll away.

Her hands hit—nothing. No resistance. Her palms cut through air, and her body lurches forward, almost stumbling.

She falls inside the doll.

Inside, a hollow dark shell. Amelie is small.

She gets up, bursts out, keeps running—heavy breath.

CUT TO:

EXT. SCHOOL FIELD - P.E. CLASS - AFTERNOON

Students running on a wide field under a pale spring sun.

Far away, students scatter in clusters: girls in tight circles, boys shouting through a baseball game. Loud.

AMELIE stops running and walks alone near the track.

YUNA jogs up beside her. She slows to match Amelie’s pace.

YUNA Amelie, let’s walk a lap together.

Amelie nods. They start along the track.

Sound of their sneakers on the rubber ground. Distant crack of a bat.

Yuna takes a breath.

YUNA (CONT’D) I heard that you are going on a tour.

Amelie glances at her. Then looks down. Painful.

AMELIE I'm not going anymore.

YUNA What? Sorry... I didn't know.

AMELIE It's okay. I have made up my mind. My grades are improving. Isn't it good?

YUNA (RAISE TONE)
Then it doesn't matter anymore.

They keep walking.

CONTINUED: (25)

YUNA (CONT'D) There's a musical I really love. *Elisabeth*. My parents took me when I was nine. I was tiny. I didn't even know what a musical was.

FLASHBACK - INT. THEATRE - NIGHT

Young YUNA leans forward in her seat, eyes wide, sparkling. Onstage, Elisabeth sings. Her voice, bright and trembling.

BACK TO FIELD.

YUNA (CONT'D) I remembered when she started singing... my tears came out immediately. I couldn't stop.

AMELIE (CONFUSED, GENTLE)
Why?

Yuna searches for the words, embarrassed by her own sincerity.

YUNA Because she's...brave. Everyone tells her to be someone she does not want to be... She does not obey.
(LOSES IN THOUGHT)
And her voice was the most beautiful thing I've ever heard.

Amelie watches Yuna as she says it. She rarely sees Yuna like this.

They sit on the artificial turf near the track. Behind them, the baseball game continues, loud but far away.

Wind moves through the field, through their hair. Amelie stares at clouds drifting slowly, then looks to the ground.

Yuna picks at a blade of turf between her fingers.

A long beat.

Then Yuna speaks again, but softer.

YUNA (CONT'D) I always think you're like Elisabeth.

Amelie turns to her, startled.

YUNA (CONT'D) You've been through a lot. I know it hasn't been easy.

She hesitates, then pushes through, voice barely above the wind.

YUNA (CONT'D) And you have such a beautiful voice. Did anyone ever tell you that?

Amelie opens her mouth. Her throat tightens.

CONTINUED: (26)

The field stays bright. The wind gently moves their hair.

A long beat.

In the distance, the P.E. teacher blows the whistle, calling everyone to gather.

YUNA (CONT'D) It's time. We'd better go.

AMELIE (TURNS TO YUNA)
You know, Yuna... I'm gonna miss you the most.

YUNA What do you mean?

AMELIE I think...maybe...I'll go.

Tears start running down her face. Yuna surpirsed. She puts both hands on Amelie's shoulders and looks at her.

YUNA (EXCITED, VOICE TREMBLES)
What...You are going to the tour?

AMELIE (NOD)
Yeah...I think I'm going.

Yuna opens her arms and pulls Amelie in.

YUNA I can't believe it... I am so happy...

AMELIE (STARTS TO SOB)
I always know I want to go. But why is it so hard to say it? Why can't I even feel any joy?

Yuna holds Amelie tighter.

YUNA It's just hard... It's a big decision.

Yuna suddenly thinks of something. She pulls back, eyes filled with excitement.

YUNA (CONT'D) But you know what! I heard that those microphones musical actors wear on their foreheads? Twenty thousand yuan each.

Amelie stops sobbing. She blinks.

AMELIE (WIPES HER TEARS)
Twenty thousand yuan?!

Yuna nods hard, dead serious.

YUNA And now you will be the one who wears them.

CONTINUED: (27)

Amelie bursts into laughter. Yuna laughs with her.

CUT TO:

INT. CLASSROOM - FRIDAY AFTERNOON

School is out. Students are cleaning the classroom, sweeping floors, snapping rags, and wiping desks.

Outside classroom, suitcases line the corridor like a train. Students take them away as they leave, one after another. Loud wheels echo.

By the window lockers, AMELIE packs quietly. She pulls mountains of exercise books out, stacking them in her suitcase with care.

She zips her suitcase halfway, adjusts the weight.

A shadow falls across her. Then another.

Amelie looks up. A small circle of classmates stands around her with brooms and rags in their hands, halfway cleaning.

At the front: ZOEY and JADE. Zoey clears her throat, acting casual.

ZOEY (AWKWARDLY)
So...

Zoey looks at Jade. Jade forces a small smile.

JADE We heard you're going to Beijing... next week?

Amelie blinks, just waits. Zoey rushes to fill the silence.

ZOEY Like—rehearsing there for two months? And then you go on a tour? The Sound of Music?

Amelie nods once. Keeps packing.

JADE (TENTATIVE)
WOW. That's impressive.

Zoey shifts.

ZOEY We'll come see you perform when you're back in Shanghai. When is it?

Amelie finishes packing. Zips the suitcase shut. She looks at them. No expression on her face. She lifts the suitcase handle.

AMELIE In June. Bye.

She turns to go. Zoey and Jade watch Amelie drag her suitcase down the corridor, alone.

(CONTINUED)

CONTINUED: (28)

They turn to look at each other, then return to cleaning.

CUT TO:

AMELIE's suitcase lies open on the bed. Books stacked tight. Clothes folded flat. She slides her violin case strap into place.

Then she sees the doll.

A beat.

She crosses to it. Picks it up carefully. For the first time, she isn't begging it for anything.

She smiles. Small, private.

AMELIE (CONT'D) (WHISPER)
Wish me luck. Will you?

She sets the doll in the drawer and closes it.

CUT TO:

EXT. TRAIN STATION PLATFORM - EARLY MORNING

Morning light is faint and cold. A thin haze of smoke rises where trains breathe.

The platform surges with travel. Suitcases rolling, wheels rattling. Voices in different dialects overlapping.

AMELIE pushes through the crowd toward GATE 6. Backpack on. Pink violin case on one shoulder.

MOTHER beside her, carrying a huge suitcase. She stops, adjusts the strap on Amelie's backpack. Straightens it.

MOTHER ID card. Wallet. Phone.
(BEAT)
You checked everything?

AMELIE Yes, Mom.

MOTHER (NOD)
I am coming with you for just one night. Tomorrow I will have to return for work. But Dad and I will visit in two weeks.

AMELIE Okay.

Mother hesitates, then speaks like she's been holding this question for days.

CONTINUED: (29)

MOTHER There's something I never asked you... Why did you call that night and change your mind?

Amelie's throat tightens.

AMELIE I... Why did you let me go?

Mother listens. Her face, first full of fear, then something else emerges underneath.

MOTHER As your mom, I shouldn't. Everything is too risky.

A beat. The crowd moves around them.

MOTHER (CONT'D) But that night... I asked myself, if I were your friend...what would I tell you?

The train slides in with a long metallic GROAN. A digital sign flashes: BEIJING BOUND. Mother's smile is small.

MOTHER (CONT'D) I hear myself say, "Go."

Amelie swallows hard. She nods. They step onto the train together.

CUT TO:

INT. TRAIN - CONTINUOUS

Crowded aisle. People wedge suitcases overhead. A child cries. A snack cart rattles past.

AMELIE finds a window seat. MOTHER sits aside.

She watches unfamiliar faces and hears dialects she can't place. A new world, huge, indifferent.

The train lurches. Outside, the platform begins to slide away.

Amelie exhales. She pulls out her earphones and listens to music.

The glass holds a faint reflection of Amelie, layered over the moving world. Fear. Hope. Something in between.

AMELIE (V.O.) I won't regret it.

A beat.

AMELIE (V.O.) (CONT'D) …Will I?

Sunlight grows stronger outside, slowly flooding the window until the world turns dazzling, almost unreal.

CONTINUED: (30)

Amelie keeps her eyes forward.

In the window’s reflection, Amelie’s school uniform flickers. For a single blink, it becomes the navy Sound of Music uniform.

Then she’s herself again.

CUT TO BLACK.